

1. THE TEACHER/ INSTITUTION CENTERED APPROACH

The teacher-centered method is historically considered the more traditional approach, the education field has evolved to recognize the significant benefits of empowering students to be more active participants in their own learning. However, there continue to be countless examples of students being challenged and transformed by a teacher lecturing about a subject they have spent their entire life exploring.

Sometimes called the “Guide on the Side” style, the student-centered model builds in more equanimity between the teacher and student, with each playing a role in the learning process. The teacher still exercises authority, but is more likely to act as a facilitator, coaching students and assisting them in their learning.

This approach, which has grown in popularity over the past several decades, champions student choice and facilitates connections among students, embracing the philosophy that, for a student to truly learn, they must be actively involved in the process.

Characteristics of teacher-centered instruction

- The teacher is the center of knowledge and in charge of learning.
- Students are usually passively receiving information.
- The instructor’s role is to be the primary information giver and primary evaluator.
- Students are viewed as “empty vessels” who passively receive knowledge from their teachers.
- Teachers and professors act as the sole supplier of knowledge, and under the direct instruction model, teachers often utilize systematic, scripted lesson plans.
- Teacher-Centered Instruction is fairly low-tech, often relying on the use of textbooks and workbooks instead of computers

Assessments are in many cases only carried out as summative and not formative evaluations and they rarely address qualitative issues of the learner’s progress.

A teacher-centered approach is one where activity in the class is centered on the teacher. It can be compared to a learner-centered approach.

Example

A typical Presentation - Practice - Production (PPP) lesson tends to be teacher-centered, as the teacher leads the activity and provides necessary information, usually in an open-class arrangement.

In the classroom Teacher-centered lessons are generally associated with traditional approaches to language learning, but teacher-centered activity can be useful in a variety of ways in teaching. The teacher is an effective model of the target language and an important source of information on how the learners are doing.

Further links:

<https://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/article/sue-sheerin-learner-centred-classroom>

<https://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/article/tbl-pbl-two-learner-centred-approaches>

2. THE STUDENT CENTRED APPROACH

The student-centered learning approach is constructivist in nature, it enables students to visualize a problem with multiple perspectives and allows them to participate in their own learning process. Students are now challenged to develop skills in problem-solving and to exercise analytical, critical and creative thinking in their work and are encouraged to learn more about their subjects. The role of the teacher now alters to being a facilitator and a consultant to the students, supporting them throughout their learning process, rather than just being a dictator in the entire process.

For teachers who wish to create a more student-centered environment, things are not always easy, since creating such an environment is an intensive process which requires a lot of consideration and knowledge. First of all, they need to come out of the practice of being the ‘sage on the stage’, and also the students who are not used to being active participants in their learning need a good deal of adjustment. Technology can help pave the way for both teachers and students, but it certainly requires a teacher who is adept at creating a course that raises the pedagogical benefits of that technology has towards helping students meet the desired learning outcomes. A roadmap needs to be followed for matching technological tools to learning outcomes, so that technology can be used to get students to interact with course content in an engaging and productive fashion.

Here are some of the **ways in which technology can help facilitate a student-centered classroom:**

- **Empower the learner:** Interactive online assignments can help students assess their learning themselves, counter their drawbacks, improve and be responsible for their own learning. Online assignments also give students opportunities to practice mastering the study material at their own pace. Teachers are not physically present while the students tackle their assignments, but their help could be sought online or afterwards, whenever students feel the need for it. The technologies that support these activities could include wikis, online quizzes, blogs and discussion boards.
- **Organize activities:** A structured and logical flow for the courses is always appreciated by students as well as teachers. If you can organize your activities well, then any kind of confusion can be avoided. Organization simplifies the workflow and approach towards learning; it eases out tasks in a systematic way. The technologies that support how you organize and communicate course materials could include an online syllabus, the learning management system and email or mobile notifications of important due dates.
- **Adopt technological tools in the classroom to teach:** When a teacher adopts technology in the classroom to aid him in teaching, he is able to create learning experiences that complement each other whether the students are learning online or are present in the

classroom physically. This helps teachers to optimize their time, efforts and resources and focus more on guiding students, rather than doing all the intensive preparations and arrangements for teaching. The technologies that support this goal include online homework, clickers and surveys.

- **Making the student responsible for his own learning:** Teachers should create such courses that allow students to practice building connections with the material and proceed at their own pace. Rather than trying to match up with the learning style of the fellow students of his class, now the student can comfortably practice and develop his skills in his own learning style, which is any day more beneficial for the student in the long run. The technologies that can be used to help students take responsibility of their learning include blogs, wikis, online quizzes, and VoiceThread.
- **Subjecting students to regular evaluation:** Evaluation certainly fosters learning and is a necessity in the process of learning. Teachers can use a variety of low-stakes grading opportunities, such as online quizzes and games. The incorporation of motivator elements like online badges and medals keep the students encouraged to learn and succeed. There are numerous technologies that can help students track their progress, including online quiz banks and online platforms that enable collaboration and peer review.

Students in technology-supported classrooms are armed with powerful tools to help them gather information, consult with fellow students or teachers and present their findings. Their confidence increases as they rely less on their teacher and more on their own initiative for knowledge-creation. Technology enables students to manipulate information in a manner that accelerates both understanding and the progression of higher-order thinking skills. As a result, students gather more real-world data, share their findings with learners beyond their school, and publish their findings to the world; their role broadens from being mere learners and knowledge seekers to being creators of their own work. For teachers, technology amplifies the resources they can offer to their students. Rather than relying on the textbook for content, computers can provide online access to content experts and up-to-date information from original sources.

Although it is undeniable that integrating technology takes a fair amount of upfront time in terms of getting past the learning curve and choosing the correct technology to support each learning objective, the result is the creation of a more engaged classroom and improved student learning. I would encourage teachers and students to come out of the traditional classrooms, incorporate technology with education and accept the fact that learning, rather than being just a practice is an active responsibility of the learners and teachers with the help of technology should assist students to have a successful education.

Learner-centered instruction empowers learners to participate actively in the learning process. Unlike more traditional teacher-centered approaches which focus on the instructor, this model places the learner at the center of the learning process. The role of the instructor goes beyond transmitting knowledge, as they take on the responsibility of facilitating active learning experiences for the learners. At the same time, learners take on a more proactive role, influencing course content and activities and actively reflecting on their learning.



Principles of Learner-Centered Instruction. Adapted from Parrish (2019)

The focus shift from teacher-centered to learner-centered instruction allows us to empower learners to take control of their own learning processes. This approach moves away from *covering* content to *employing* content in order to help learners develop skills that will be applicable to real-world situations. Through authentic assessments and feedback, learners have the opportunity to reflect on what they are learning and how they are learning it.

The table below provides a comparison between teacher-centered and learner-centered instructional models.

• Teacher-centered Instructional Model	• Learner-centered Instructional Model
• Places the instructor at the center of the learning process	• Places the learner at the center of the learning process
• Instructor imparts knowledge, not involving learners in the learning process	• Instructor serves as a facilitator, involving learners in the learning process

• Instructor chooses topics and activities; learners participate passively	• Learners influence topics and activities and participate actively
• Assessments are one-dimensional and focus on grading	• Assessments are multidimensional and provide ongoing feedback
• Prioritizes memorization and correctness	• Prioritizes higher-level thinking
• Academic culture is competitive and individualistic	• Academic culture is collaborative and supportive

Weimer (2013) describes 5 key changes to practice:

1. **Balance of power:** challenge the traditional power structure and the role of authority in the classroom.
2. **Function of content:** focus on higher-order thinking rather than memorization, allowing learners to actively explore and reflect on their learning.
3. **Role of the instructor:** serve as a facilitator that promotes learning rather than a content expert or authoritarian classroom manager.
4. **Responsibility of learning:** promote independent, active and autonomous learning, as learners become more responsible for their own learning.
5. **Evaluation purposes and processes:** utilize assessments as tools to promote learning and not tools to generate grades. Incorporate authentic assessments with meaningful, ongoing feedback.

References

Parrish, B. (2019). *Teaching Adult English Language Learners: A Practical Introduction Paperback* (2nd ed.). Cambridge University Press.

Weimer, M. (2013). *Learner-Centered Teaching: Five Key Changes to Practice* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.

3. THE KELLER PLANNED APPROACH

The Keller Plan is a personalized learning method in which students receive material in small units. When they are ready, they take a test on the unit they have just completed. If they pass, they then move onto the next unit. Learners progress at a comfortable pace, i.e., their own pace.

We also refer to the Keller Plan as the PSI. PSI stands for the Personalized System of Instruction. Fred S. Keller, alongside Carolina Bori, Rodolpho Azzi, and J. Gilmour Sherman developed the plan in the 1960s.

Keller Plan instructors are, in fact, facilitators. The system has no punishments, and the instructors simply award pass or fail grades.

The Keller Plan was an innovative instruction method for the University of Brasilia, which opened in 1962.

According to Learning Theories:

“The Keller Plan (also called The Personalized System of Instruction) is an instructional method introduced by Fred Keller, J. Gilmour Sherman, and several other researchers in the 1960s.”

“This individualized learning method was oriented on improvement of high school learning.”

- **The Keller Plan – individual needs**

Fred Keller wanted to tailor higher education teaching to the learner’s specific needs.

He first introduced the method in 1962 in the University of Brasilia’s Department of Psychology.

Educationalists say that the key features of Keller’s methods are the following:

- **Learning Pace**

Learners progress at their own pace. The study group does not progress as one unit. In other words, each student progresses independently of other students.

Instructors suggest the order in which students should progress through the learning units. However, it is ultimately the student’s decision when they learn. It is also the student’s decision at what rate learning progresses.

- **Mastery of Each Unit**

To advance from one unit to the next, the student must master a unit first.

When students pass an exam, they can then choose which unit to do next. However, if they fail, the instructor directs them to unit materials.

After studying those materials, they then do another exam.

- **Written Learning Materials**

The bulk of the course consists of written learning materials. There are lectures and demonstrations. However, students only attend them when they are ready to appreciate them.

None of the exam questions relate to the lectures or demonstrations. Therefore, attending the demonstrations and lectures is optional.

- **Proctors**

According to Learning Theories: “Proctors enhance the social aspect of educational process, enable repeated testing with immediate scoring and tutoring.”

4. MIX AND MATCH APPROACH

Every teacher needs an active learning strategy toolbox. It is nice to be able to vary your strategies and bring out a new activity when learning starts to feel stagnant, when students are restless, or when you or the students are feeling bored with the same old activities. A new active learning strategy can revitalize your classroom and leave everyone feeling energized.

The activity we are sharing today is an easy activity that you can do in ten or fifteen minutes. It works for all grade levels and all subject areas. This activity is great for reviewing previously taught concepts or introducing new ones by connecting to students' previous knowledge.

Mix and Match Active Learning Strategy

You will need some index cards and a set of questions and answers.

Divide the number of students in your class in half. Prepare a set of questions and answers for half the number of students in your class. If you have an uneven number, round up.

Write the question on an index card. Write the answer on a separate index card.

Shuffle the cards.

Give one card to each student. Their goal is to walk around the room, read each other's questions and answers and find the person with the card that matches their own card. When they find the person whose card matches their own, they stand together as a pair.

Once the students have matched up, invite each pair to share their question and answer. The class gives a thumbs up or thumbs down to show that they think the match is correct or incorrect. You can also use this time to stretch the question, discuss why the answer is correct or incorrect or extend the information in some way.

If you have an uneven number of students in your class you can take a card and participate yourself or offer the extra card to the first pair who has finished and allow them to make a second pair.

This activity can engage students in many ways. They have an opportunity for physical movement, which many students need and enjoy. They work together and cooperate with others in a very structured and low threat way. The questions themselves offer opportunity to engage in critical thinking as they decide whether questions and answers are a match or not. You can also vary the levels of the questions to include lower level recall questions or higher-level application, analysis and synthesis questions.

You can also develop variations on this strategy. Students can write the questions. You can make it more difficult by connecting three different cards. You can use it without questions by connecting vocabulary words that share a meaning or are connected in some way. We've also used it to have students match punctuation to sentences or categories to words such as matching weather terms to classifications such as types of clouds, tools for measuring weather and types of precipitation.

Use your imagination and you will be able to come up with unique and fun learning opportunities with this simple active learning strategy.